

On Liberty



The British police force was established to protect the interests of the people rather than to impose authoritarian laws.

In Bentham's utilitarianism, the rightness of actions is judged by their consequences, how much pleasure or pain they cause. This was in distinct contrast to Immanuel Kant's system of moral philosophy based on the motives of an action and a moral 'categorical imperative', which influenced European ideas of morality (see [Idealism and nature](#)). The British liberal, *laissez-faire* approach to government and economics also distinguished it

from more ideological political philosophies elsewhere. The morality of motives, such as the self-interest pointed out by Adam Smith (see [Political economy](#)), is less important than the beneficial results for society. John Stuart Mill, whose father was a friend of Bentham, was a great advocate of utilitarian moral principles, but also of liberal political ideals of personal freedom. In his book *On Liberty*, Mill offered a less rigid version of utilitarianism, shifting the emphasis to the liberty of the individual and introducing the 'harm principle'. In his opinion, people should be free to do as they like, so long as it does not harm anyone else or restrict their ability to do the same.